

replaced by a willingness to get something for nothing, and thus he never learns one of the basic lessons of life.

Great fortunes or modest fortunes are a blessing only when they are used in good part to benefit others. No father benefits his son when he robs him of initiative. No testator favors a beneficiary by making it unnecessary for him to work. You may wish to shield your inheritors from the meanness of poverty. Well and good! Beyond that, do not shield them from life with a wall of money. Let them have the priceless opportunity of building better lives with their own life-taught wisdom and their own constructive work.

In my youth I worked as a secretary to a wealthy lawyer who had two sons somewhat older than myself. These youths attended the University of Virginia. It became my duty to make up for each of them a monthly check for one hundred dollars as spending money. In those days a hundred dollars would buy three or four times what it will today. How I envied those boys!

When I had been in business college, learning how to earn my own living, I had often gone hungry because I literally did not have a cent in my pocket. I vividly recall standing in front of a store and longing for some apples which were priced six for a dime. At length I went in and sold the store-keeper on the idea of trusting me for the dime until I got through school and began to earn money. Such were my memories as I made out those magnificent monthly checks.

By and by my employer's sons came home with their diplomas. They also came home conditioned to easy living and with little idea of what work is all about. Were they inherently as capable as their father? We shall never know. One of them was put into a good job in a bank his father owned, and another was made manager of one of his father's coal mines.

Ten years later they had completely wrecked their father's fortune and his health as well.

I no longer envy anyone, for envy is no part of peace of mind. As I look back, I am grateful that I had to undergo such experiences as negotiating a ten-cent long-term credit. And I am grateful that, when I began to earn money, my earning power became part of my self-fulfillment. I am even glad that when I made mistakes and lost money, I had no rich father to see me through, for I found a mighty teacher in adversity.

My book *Think and Grow Rich* has been read by perhaps seven million men and women. In the twenty years since it